

initial result is always frustrating: each bucket fills up, starting with the “validated” bucket and moving on to the “done” bucket, until it’s not possible to start any more work. Teams that are used to measuring their productivity narrowly, by the number of stories they are delivering, feel stuck. The only way to start work on new features is to investigate some of the stories that are done but haven’t been validated. That often requires nonengineering efforts: talking to customers, looking at split-test data, and the like.

Pretty soon everyone gets the hang of it. This progress occurs in fits and starts at first. Engineering may finish a big batch of work, followed by extensive testing and validation. As engineers look for ways to increase their productivity, they start to realize that if they include the validation exercise from the beginning, the whole team can be more productive.

For example, why build a new feature that is not part of a split-test experiment? It may save you time in the short run, but it will take more time later to test, during the validation phase. The same logic applies to a story that an engineer doesn’t understand. Under the old system, he or she would just build it and find out later what it was for. In the new system, that behavior is clearly counterproductive: without a clear hypothesis, how can a story ever be validated? We saw this behavior at IMVU, too. I once saw a junior engineer face down a senior executive over a relatively minor change. The engineer insisted that the new feature be split-tested, just like any other. His peers backed him up; it was considered absolutely obvious that all features should be routinely tested, no matter who was commissioning them. (Embarrassingly, all too often I was the executive in question.) A solid process lays the foundation for a healthy culture, one where ideas are evaluated by merit and not by job title.

Most important, teams working in this system begin to measure their productivity according to validated learning, not in terms of the production of new features.